

How Translation Really Works

Meaning, tone, register, audience and culture - explained simply.

Translation is not word-swapping

A good translation moves meaning, not just words. The same sentence can be correct grammatically and still feel wrong if the tone, the audience or the cultural context is ignored. Professionals work on six layers at once.

The six layers

Layer	Question it answers
Meaning	What is actually being said?
Tone	Is it warm, formal, playful, urgent?
Register	Academic, business, casual, technical?
Audience	Who reads this, and what do they expect?
Format	Headings, tables, length, UI limits?
Culture	Idioms, examples, units, references that must adapt?

A small example

English “You’re all set!” is friendly and informal. A literal Spanish version sounds odd; “¡Todo listo!” keeps the meaning and the friendly tone. That single choice is translation working on meaning + tone + culture together.

How to get a better translation

- Tell the translator the audience and purpose, not just the language pair.
- Share a glossary or preferred terms if you have them.
- Send the final text (not a draft) and the file format you need back.
- Allow a revision round for tone and terminology.

RESUMEN EN ESPAÑOL

Traducir no es cambiar palabras: es trasladar significado cuidando tono, registro, audiencia, formato y cultura al mismo tiempo. Para recibir una mejor traducción, indica el público y el propósito, comparte tu glosario, envía el texto final y permite una ronda de revisión.

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